Trauma Writing and Climate Migration Narratives

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Introduction

In an era where climate change intensifies displacement on a global scale, novels that explore climate-induced migrations provide a fertile ground for examining the interplay of trauma, memory, and environmental degradation. This research focuses on detecting traces of trauma in a corpus of contemporary novels that depict climate migrations. These narratives emphasize impending trauma, aligning with concepts of "pre-traumatic stress disorder" (Kaplan 2016) and "anticipatory memory" (Craps 2017). This dual focus encapsulates two traumatic dimensions: the devastating nature of the migratory journey and the forewarning of future ecological catastrophes.

However, while these narratives employ trauma as a central motif, it is crucial to differentiate between trauma tied to a lived event and pre-trauma, a signifier anticipating a catastrophic signified that has yet to materialize. These novels also extend beyond human experiences, engaging with the planetary scale of climate change, which often manifests through "eco-trauma" (Narine 2015). By linking human and non-human migrations, these texts interrogate the boundaries of human-centered narratives in environmental discourse.

This project utilizes text analysis methods to uncover patterns of trauma representation across the corpus, aiming to bridge computational text analysis with literary close reading through "computational hermeneutics" (Piper 2015). The study asks: How are trauma, pre-trauma, and eco-trauma encoded in climate migration novels, and what do these representations reveal about the cultural imagination of climate change?

Corpus and Methodology

The study comprises a small corpus of contemporary novels that center on climate-induced migrations, selected for their thematic focus, geographical diversity, and temporal range. Texts span regions disproportionately affected by climate change, such as the Global South, as well as speculative futures imagined by authors worldwide. This diversity ensures a holistic exploration of climate migrations across cultural and ecological contexts.

The project employs several methodological steps: First of all, by employing SentimentArcs, developed by Jon Chun and Katherine Elkins, it adopts sentiments analysis to identify emotionally charged passages, focusing on language indicative of despair, fear, or hope (Elkins and Chun 2019). This analysis helps trace moments where trauma or anticipatory stress emerges. The next step entails topic modelling to extract recurring themes such as displacement, ecological degradation, and survival, identifying overlaps between human and ecological concerns. Finally, semantic analysis helps detect phrases and motifs associated with pre-trauma and eco-trauma, illuminating how these concepts operate within the texts' narrative structures, focusing on common tropes for representing trauma in fiction: absence, repetition, and indirection (Pederson 2018).

This approach complements traditional close reading, enabling a macro-level perspective on trauma representation while retaining the capacity for nuanced textual interpretation. This mixed-method approach aligns with the project's aim to uncover both quantitative patterns and qualitative subtleties.

Objectives

The project has three key objectives:

1. To analyze how trauma, pre-trauma, and eco-trauma are represented across the corpus, focusing on narrative techniques and recurring motifs,
2. To investigate the relationship between human and non-human migrations in these texts, exploring their implications for the anthropocentric bias in environmental discourse,
3. To assess whether these representations challenge or reinforce dominant narratives of climate change, particularly in their portrayal of resilience, vulnerability, and ecological interconnectedness.

Preliminary Findings and Insights

Early explorations of the corpus suggest that pre-trauma and anticipatory memory often operate as structural devices, framing narratives

around warnings of irreversible ecological damage. For instance, passages describing mass migrations are frequently interspersed with imagined futures, blurring the boundary between lived and anticipated trauma. Similarly, eco-trauma emerges in depictions of displaced animal species or altered ecosystems, highlighting the shared precarity of human and non-human life. These findings underscore the novels' dual function: they bear witness to the human cost of climate migrations while drawing attention to the broader planetary crisis. This duality not only enriches the narratives but also positions them as critical interventions in climate change discourse, emphasizing the urgency of collective action.

Bibliography

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